

FIFTY-STATE INITIATIVE

Super Heroes for All of America

50-STATE INITIATIVE

FACTFILE

CURRENT MEMBERS

ANT-MAN (Eric O'Grady) Can shrink or grow to dramatic sizes.

GAUNTLET Drill sergeant with an alien superweapon.

MUTANT ZERO (Typhoid Mary) Telekinesis, telepathy, and pyrokinesis.

TASKMASTER Martial arts expert with photographic reflexes.

TRAUMA Telepath and shapeshifter.

BARON VON BLITZSCHLAG Scientific genius and electricity control.

ADDITIONAL MEMBERS ARMORY, CLOUD 9, HARDBALL, MICHAEL VAN PATRICK, and many others.

BASE Camp Hammond, Stamford, Connecticut

FIRST APPEARANCE Civil War: The Initiative #1 (April, 2007)

ALLIES The Dark Avengers.

FOES The New Avengers.

ALLIES/FOES

ISSUE #1

As the new leader of SHIELD, Tony Stark considers how to best organize the heroes available to him.



After the passage of the Superhuman Registration Act, Tony Stark (IRON MAN) realized that SHIELD needed a plan for how to make use of all of the Super Heroes soon to be under its remit. During the Civil War (see pp. 84-5), he, Mr. FANTASTIC, and Hank PYM brainstormed a long list of ideas for how to improve the world. The Fifty State Initiative was number 41 on that list.

HEROES UNITED AND DEPLOYED

To get the Initiative started, Stark funded a superteam of his own: the ORDER. This team was ready to see action in the final battle of the Civil War. When Stark was made the director of SHIELD after the Civil War, he had the power to build a Super Hero team for each state in the nation, based on that prototype.

Many of the initial teams were simply existing teams or heroes brought into the new structure. The GREAT LAKE AVENGERS, for example, were renamed the Great Lakes Initiative and assigned to their home state of Wisconsin, while HELICAT was sent to Alaska to serve as its hero.



Gauntlet—the drill sergeant at Camp Hammond—greeted the first busload of trainees as they arrive.

HERO BOOT CAMP

Many new heroes joined the Initiative, and these trained to make the best use of their powers and reduce the danger they presented to the world. To this end, Stark set up Camp Hammond as the Initiative's headquarters and training center. Sergeant Joe Green (GAUNTLET) served as the drill instructor under administrator Henry Peter GYRICH with Hank Pym as the chief administrator, and Baron Werner Von Blitzschlag in charge of the science division. Gyrich formed a black ops team answerable only to himself, called the Shadow Initiative. Members included Bengal, Constrictor, the Scarlet Spiders, and Mutant Zero (TYPHOID MARY).



Stark formed the Order as a template for the Initiative. The California team was the first generated specifically for the program.

EARLY TROUBLES

In the first combat training session, a terrified ARMORY fired the Tactigon wildly and killed fellow recruit Michael Van PATRICK. The following cover-up came back to haunt the Initiative when Von Blitzschlag fitted a clone of Van Patrick with the Tactigon, causing him to become psychotic and go on a murderous rampage.

Initiative recruits helped during World War Hulk (see pp. 152-5) and the Secret Invasion (see pp. 326-7). In the confusion surrounding the Hulk's attack, SLAPSTICK beat Gauntlet into a coma for berating the New Warriors, of which Slapstick had once been a member. Gauntlet later recovered.

SHIELD scientists developed Super-Power-Inhibiting Nanobots (SPIN) technology that could be used to remove superpowers.

HYDRA leader Senator WOODMAN persuaded Initiative recruit HARDBALL to steal this for him. Later, when Woodman blackmailed Hardball into continuing to work for him, Hardball killed him, left the Initiative, and took over the leadership of HYDRA instead.

THE SKRULL INFILTRATION

Before the Secret Invasion, the SKRULL Queen VERANKE made sure to insert a Skrull into every team in all 50 states. When the Skrulls launched their attack, many of the spies revealed themselves, and the rest of the Initiative's

members could not tell who to trust. Using 3-D MAN's powers, TRIATHLON managed to spot most of them located at Camp Hammond, but few other teams were so lucky.

In the aftermath, DOC SAMSON held group therapy sessions for those people who were kidnapped and replaced by Skrulls. However, the Skrull who had impersonated Hank Pym for his entire time with the Initiative reactivated the clone of THOR that had killed GIANT-MAN during the Civil War (see pp. 84-5).

After helping to stop the clone's rampage, the members of an underground team called Counter Force—made up of former New Warriors—revealed to reporters the scandal behind MVP's death and the subsequent cover-up.

When Norman Osborn (GREEN GOBLIN), became director of HAMMER, he took the opportunity to shut down Camp Hammond. He then secretly placed

TASKMASTER and the HOOD in charge so that they could use the base to create new forces for Osborn's Dark Avengers team. MF



The Thunderbolts were brought into the Initiative.



When the Civil War ended, Stark faced a flood of registered heroes to choose from for the Initiative's teams.

MAIN STORYLINES

• **Civil War: The Initiative #1** As the new leader of SHIELD, Tony Stark considers how to best organize the heroes available to him.

• **Avengers: The Initiative #1** The first team of recruits arrives at Camp Hammond and promptly suffers its first disaster with the training death of MVP.

• **Avengers: The Initiative #8-11** KIA is created and nearly destroys the Initiative.